

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science

Module outline — Michaelmas Term 2026

Dr Noah Buckley

4 September 2026

The essentials

Module	POU11011: Introduction to Political Science (A)
Term	Michaelmas Term 2026 / Semester 1, 2026–27
Credits	5 ECTS · Junior Fresh · Department of Political Science
Lecturer	Dr Noah Buckley — buckleno@tcd.ie
Office hours	By appointment — email to arrange a time
Lectures	Tuesdays 11:00 and Thursdays 11:00 · rooms [TBD: lecture venues]
Teaching weeks	Ten, on TCD’s teaching-week calendar: teaching weeks 2–6 (22 September – 23 October), then teaching weeks 8–12 (3 November – 4 December)
Reading/review week	Teaching week 7, w/c Monday 26 October — no teaching
Tutorials	Four sessions across the term, TA-led · dates [TBD: tutorial schedule] · groups allocated by the department through your timetable [TBD: confirm dept allocates via my.tcd.ie timetable, no sign-up needed]
Teaching assistants	[TBD: TA names and email addresses]
Course website	noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011 [TBD: confirm final URL]
Assessment	Discussion points + tutorials 10% · short assignment 30% · final essay 60%

Module description

This module introduces you to the big questions in politics and to the conceptual, theoretical, and analytical tools that political scientists use to answer them. It is designed both for students who intend to study politics for the rest of their degree and for those taking a single, standalone introduction to the discipline.

We start from the basics — what politics *is*, what power is, why states exist and why some of them work and others don’t. From there we take on ideologies and political identity, democracy and dictatorship and the grey zone in between, corruption and state capture, political institutions, and the question of who gets what in the economy. We close on the two things that make political

science a *science*: collective action problems, and how you would ever know whether a claim about politics is true.

The goal is not to memorise facts. It is to learn to think like a political scientist: to ask sharper questions, compare across cases, and carry a small toolkit of portable concepts into political situations you have never seen before.

Aims

The module has two aims: (1) to give you a basic knowledge of the key problems and questions around which politics revolves; and (2) to equip you with the fundamental conceptual, theoretical, and analytical tools used in the consideration of political questions.

Learning outcomes

On successful completion of this module, you should be able to:

- Identify and understand the key problems and questions around which politics revolves.
- Employ the fundamental conceptual, theoretical, and analytical tools used in the consideration of political questions.
- Critically engage with and analyse contemporary national and global political events and issues using the tools and frameworks of political science.

How the module works

Lectures

There are **twenty lectures** — two a week, Tuesdays and Thursdays at 11:00 — across ten teaching weeks. Attendance is not taken and there is no penalty for missing a lecture, but the lectures are where the module actually happens. Material will be covered in lecture that is not in the readings, and the slides are a prompt for what I said, not a transcript of it. You will not be able to reconstruct a lecture from the slides, and tutorials are not a place to catch up on lectures you missed. To do well here you need to do the readings, come to the lectures, and take part in tutorial discussion.

Lectures are participatory. I will ask the room what it thinks, and I would like an answer. Some lectures may be recorded, but you should not count on recordings being available, and access is not automatic.

Slides are posted on the course website after each lecture.

Tutorials

There are **four tutorial sessions** across the term, run in small groups of around twenty students by our teaching assistants. Tutorials are not weekly, and they are not repeat lectures: they are where you ask questions, argue with the readings, put a view to the room, and hear what your classmates make of it. Tutorial group assignment appears in your timetable.

Attendance at tutorials is compulsory and is linked to assessment (see below).

You do not sign up for a tutorial group. The department allocates groups and they appear in your my.tcd.ie timetable before teaching starts. If no tutorial group appears in your timetable by the end of teaching week 3, email your TA — not me — and we will sort it out. [TBD: confirm with the department that allocation is automatic via timetable and that there is no sign-up step this year.]

Tutorial dates: [TBD — **four dates, confirmed once timetabling is complete**]. With only four sessions, missing one costs you a quarter of the component, so put them in a calendar the day they are published.

Tutorials are a place for open, warm, and sometimes contentious discussion. People in the room have different backgrounds, experiences, and personal stakes in these questions. Engage seriously with the arguments and generously with the people making them.

Readings and the textbook

The core text is:

Andrew Heywood & Matthew Laing, *Politics*, 6th edition (Bloomsbury, 2025).

Chapter numbering is unchanged from the 2019 5th edition, so an older or second-hand copy is entirely fine — do not buy the newest edition on my account. A copy is provided in the **Textbook** item on Blackboard.

Each week has a small number of **required readings** you should complete *before* the relevant lecture, plus **recommended readings** for going deeper, for the assignments, and for your own interest. Additional readings beyond the textbook are provided via Blackboard. The reading list in the schedule below is indicative and may be adjusted during term; Blackboard and the course website carry the current version.

Two optional books, useful if you want a second angle on the regimes and institutions material: Patrick O’Neil, *Essentials of Comparative Politics* (Norton); and, pitched a level up, Clark, Golder & Golder, *Principles of Comparative Politics*.

Where things live

- **Blackboard** — official notices, the textbook, readings, and *all* assignment submissions (via Turnitin). Anything time-sensitive or submission-related is here.
- **Course website** — lecture slides, posted after each lecture, and the reading list.

Check both.

Assessment

Component	Weight
Discussion-point submissions + tutorial attendance	10%
Short written assignment (blog post)	30%

Component	Weight
End-of-term final essay	60%

There is **no final examination** in this module. Full assignment instructions, prompts and essay questions are released in lecture and on Blackboard.

Four handouts carry the detail, and you should read each one *before* you start the piece it covers:

- **Discussion points and tutorials** — the 10%.
- **Short assignment: the blog post** — the 30%.
- **Final essay** — the 60%.
- **Marking rubric** — how the blog post and essay are marked.

Discussion points and tutorial attendance (10%)

Across the term's four tutorials you submit **three sets of discussion points** — three numbered points, at most a page, before the tutorial — and attend the tutorial in question. Both halves are required: points without attendance, or attendance without points, earn no credit for that tutorial.

You are not being asked for polished analysis. You are being asked to raise something worth twenty minutes of argument, so that your TA can build the session around what the room actually wants to fight about.

Submissions are **pass/fail**: two points for each tutorial attended with an accepted submission, to a maximum of six across three tutorials. Your TA can reject a submission that is too short or makes no genuine attempt at the reading. Deadline is **20:00 the evening before** your tutorial meets, via Blackboard; nothing is accepted after the tutorial has met.

Points attach to **tutorials 2, 3 and 4**; tutorial 1 is orientation. Deadlines: [TBD: three dates, set once tutorial dates are confirmed.]

Department policy: this component is capped at 80. Perfect attendance and participation earns a mark of 80 for this component, with reductions proportional to that. This reflects the realities of the Trinity marking scale.

Full mechanics — what to write, what does not count, excused absence, the GenAI line — are in the **discussion points handout**.

Short assignment — blog post (30%)

An **800-word blog post** taking one concept from the module and using it to make sense of one real political situation. It is deliberately lower-stakes practice at the core move of the discipline — applying a tool to a case — before the final essay.

- **Length:** 800 words. References, links and image captions do not count. State your word count at the top. Going over incurs a penalty of three per cent.

- **Style:** rigorous but less formal than an academic essay. Headings, short paragraphs, bold text, links and images are all welcome; a real argument underneath is required. It is not an opinion piece with citations bolted on, and it is not an essay with subheadings.
- **Sources:** cite **at least two** academic readings or materials from the module.
- **Prompts released:** [TBD — roughly three weeks before the deadline], tied to what is actually happening in the world at the time.
- **Due:** [TBD: deadline, expected around the study/review week, 23:00].

The genre spec, a structure that works, the prompt options and the failure modes that cost most marks are in the [short assignment handout](#). Marking bands are in the [rubric](#).

Final essay (60%)

A **1,500-word essay** answering one of several set questions, drawing on the concepts, tools and cases from across the module. I am looking for more than recall: take a position, compare across cases, and reason with the module's toolkit.

- **Length:** 1,500 words, excluding references and footnotes (unless a footnote carries substantive content). State your word count at the top. Going over incurs a penalty of three per cent.
- **Questions released:** [TBD: date — about a month before the deadline].
- **Due:** [TBD: deadline, in the College assessment session, 11–22 December 2026, 23:00].

There is no examination. Questions, how to structure an argumentative essay at this level, citation expectations and the GenAI permissions for this piece are in the [final essay handout](#); marking bands are in the [rubric](#).

Written work: format requirements

In line with department guidelines, written work for this module must:

- state the final word count, and observe the word limit;
- be submitted to Blackboard in Word or PDF, with the Assignment Submission Form as page 1;
- use consistent citation and referencing (the [TCD Library style guide](#) will help);
- include an alphabetised bibliography;
- be spellchecked.

Back your work up, and submit early enough to survive a technical problem. Keep your submission receipt. Computer crashes, corrupted files, and internet problems are not grounds for late submission.

Policies

Excused absence from tutorials

If you need an absence from a tutorial excused for certified medical reasons, your **College Tutor** must contact both your TA and me to make the request. Only requests from College Tutors are considered. If you want module credit for that tutorial, the discussion points must still be submitted

— at or before the next tutorial, or within one week of the end of term if it relates to the last tutorial. It is your responsibility to make sure your College Tutor knows the correct procedure.

Late work

All late work, unless excused in advance by me, is penalised at **5 marks per day or part thereof, up to a maximum of 20 marks**. There are many good reasons a student cannot submit on time and I am happy to make reasonable accommodations. What is not reasonable is getting in touch after the deadline, or a few hours before it. Do not leave requests until the last minute. Department policy does not allow extensions to be granted retrospectively except in exceptional medical circumstances. Requests for extensions go through your College Tutor; late submission on medical grounds requires a medical certificate. Work is not accepted after it has been marked and returned to other students, or after the end of teaching term — in those cases the mark is 0.

Academic integrity and plagiarism

Do not plagiarise. Academic dishonesty is a serious matter with serious consequences, up to and including no credit for the assignment, failure of the module, and expulsion. It is never permissible to submit work containing other people's ideas without acknowledgment, and careless note-taking is not an excuse: put direct quotations in quotation marks, and reference paraphrases too. Trinity's guidance is at libguides.tcd.ie/plagiarism, and if you have not already completed the Library's [Ready, Steady, Write](#) tutorial, do that before your first submission. You must also submit only *new* work — not work submitted previously for another module.

Generative AI

These tools exist, you use them, and you will use them in whatever you do after this degree. Pretending otherwise would waste both our time. But this module is not assessing whether you can obtain a competent paragraph about political science — that is now free, and worth roughly what it costs. It is assessing whether *you* can read an argument, find its weak point, and put your own case in your own words. That capacity is built by doing the work, and it does not survive being outsourced. So the line I draw is this: **use these tools to help you think and to help you fix your prose; do not use them to do the thinking or produce the prose**. Where exactly that line falls differs by assignment, so it is set out below assignment by assignment. Disclose what you did on the submission form. I am not interested in policing you, and I am not going to run your work through a detector and accuse you on that basis — the detectors do not work well enough for that. I am interested in you being straight with me, and in you being able to think when there is no model in the room.

Permissions are set for **each assessment separately**, in the vocabulary of the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form, so that the words in this syllabus and the boxes you tick on the form are the same words. “Permitted” means you may do it and must tick the corresponding box. “Not permitted” means doing it is an academic integrity matter, whether or not you disclose it.

Discussion points (10%)

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	This is the expected answer.
Brainstorming	Not permitted. The point of the exercise is that <i>you</i> had a reaction to the reading.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted for one thing only: clarifying a term or passage you could not follow after genuinely trying. Not for summarising the reading — asking a model what an article says instead of reading it defeats the entire component, and your TA will be able to tell.
Writing assistance	Not permitted. These are one page, ungraded on style, and written for your TA. Spellcheck is fine.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted.

These are low-stakes and frequent, so honesty matters more here than polish. A rough, obviously human page is worth more than a smooth one.

Short assignment — blog post (30%)

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	Always fine. No penalty and no advantage — this is not a virtue signal.
Brainstorming	Permitted. Explore angles, argue with it about your thesis, generate objections to argue against.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted, with a warning. Use it to unpack a concept or a hard passage — then verify against the module readings. Do not ask it for references: it invents them, and a fabricated citation is a fabricated citation regardless of origin.
Writing assistance	Permitted, slightly wider than for the essay. Register is part of what this assignment practises, so you may ask for feedback on tone and blog-style structure, and may have it rework passages you wrote. The argument, the case, and the analysis must be yours from the start. Substantially revise and fact-check anything it hands back — you own every word you submit.

Submission-form category	This assessment
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted in the body of the post. <i>Exception:</i> if the AI output is itself your object of analysis, you may quote it, in quotation marks, cited per the Library guide , and flagged on the form.
Other use	Describe it on the form. If in doubt, ask me <i>before</i> the deadline; asking is never held against you.

Final essay (60%)

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	Always fine.
Brainstorming	Permitted. Explore angles, argue with it about your thesis, generate counterarguments to argue against.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted, with a warning. Use it to unpack a concept — then verify against the module readings. Do not ask it for references. Sources must be ones you have actually read.
Writing assistance	Permitted only for text you have already drafted yourself — tightening, grammar, clarity, structural critique of your own draft. Generating a section from a prompt and then editing it is not “writing assistance”; that is the next row. This is deliberately narrower than the submission form’s own wording of this category, which is why it is spelled out here. If you use it, add a one-line note in an appendix saying which tool and what you used it for.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted. No AI-generated text in the submitted essay, quoted and cited or otherwise. In a 1,500-word essay every sentence is supposed to be your reasoning.
Other use	Describe it on the form, or ask me before the deadline.

The examination

There is no examination in this module. *[TBD: Noah to confirm this line stays accurate — the assessment table above says no final exam.]*

The Assignment Submission Form — required on every submission

Every piece of written work submitted for this module must have the **School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form** attached as its first page. The form is on Blackboard in both Word and PDF. Complete it in full, including the plagiarism declaration and the GenAI disclosure — tick every category that applies to what you actually did, and use the *Other use* box if none of them fits.

A written submission received without a completed form is not accepted. It is returned to you unmarked, and the work is treated as not submitted until you resubmit it with a completed form attached — accruing the late penalties set out under **Late work** above for every day in between. This is a departmental requirement and applies across the module.

The form does not count toward your word limit. Ticking a box that the policy above permits carries no penalty of any kind.

[TBD: Noah to confirm two things — (a) whether the form is required for discussion points as well as the two graded assignments (this syllabus currently implies yes; recommendation is to exempt them explicitly), and (b) whether TAs give a 48-hour penalty-free window to supply a missing form before late penalties start running.]

If something looks wrong

Detection software does not settle this. Turnitin’s own documentation concedes a false-positive rate, and detectors misflag writing by people who learned English as a second language far more often than they misflag anyone else. **I will not accuse anyone on the basis of a detector score, and no mark in this module will be reduced because software produced a number.**

What actually happens: if something in a submission does not add up — an argument that does not match your other work, sources that do not exist or do not say what they are cited as saying, a disclosure that does not fit what is on the page — I will ask you to come and talk about it. That conversation is not a disciplinary hearing. Bring your notes, your drafts, your reading. Most of these conversations end there.

If the conversation does not resolve it, the matter goes through Trinity’s normal academic integrity route — the College Academic Integrity Policy and the associated procedure for suspected misconduct — and out of my hands. Submitting AI-generated content as your own work is plagiarism under College policy, and so is undisclosed use. That route is the same one that has always applied to plagiarism; nothing about it is AI-specific.

The baseline is Trinity’s [Statement on Generative AI](#), the Library’s [GenAI guide](#), and the College [GenAI hub](#). Where this syllabus is stricter than the baseline, this syllabus governs.

Contacting us

Check the [FAQ](#) first — extensions, missed tutorials, readings, mark queries, and GenAI questions are all answered there.

There are around five hundred of you and one of me, so email has an order.

Start with your own TA. Anything about module content, readings, tutorials, your discussion points, or how an assignment works goes to the teaching assistant who runs your tutorial group. They are closest to your work and they are happy to meet on request.

Come to me second, and only for things a TA cannot settle — extensions, serious personal difficulty, a mark you believe is wrong after you have already discussed it with your TA, or a question about the module as a whole. When you do, **copy your TA** so we are not answering you separately.

The TAs and I will do our best to reply within **two business days**. Emails sent at midnight before a deadline will not be answered before it.

Please do not email either of us to ask: when something is due, where the slides are, what the word limit is, whether the lecture was recorded, what the reading is this week, or whether you can have an extension without going through your College Tutor. All of that is in this document, on Blackboard, or on the course website. **Check there first** — it is faster than we are, and it keeps the inbox clear for people with real problems.

For substantive questions about the material, come to office hours (by appointment — email to arrange). I will not be able to fill you in on a lecture you missed, but I am glad to talk through anything you are uncertain about.

Disability

Students with a disability liable to affect their ability to participate fully in this — or any — module are encouraged to register with the University's [Disability Service](#), which exists to make sure appropriate accommodations are in place.

Keeping up with current events

Read the news. Any serious source you like, national and international. Half the value of this module is having something concrete in your head when a concept turns up, and the other half is noticing that a concept explains something you read last week.

I reserve the right to modify this outline as necessary during term. The current version is always the one on the course website and Blackboard.

Schedule

Week numbers follow Trinity's teaching-week calendar (teaching week 1 begins 14 September); as a first-year module, this one starts lectures in teaching week 2.

Twenty lectures across ten teaching weeks, in five parts. Readings below are indicative; confirm against Blackboard. "H&L" = Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, 6th ed.

Each week is motivated by a **big question**. The lectures are two attempts at it; the readings are the evidence. Where I know a reading is hard or short, I have said so.

Part I — Foundations

Teaching week 2 · Tue 22 & Thu 24 September

Big question: what is politics, and who actually decides?

- **Lecture 1 — Is this politics?** A rent freeze, a nurses' strike, a viral post, a coup. Politics as collective choice under conflict.
- **Lecture 2 — Power: who actually decides?** The three faces of power, and the harder question: how would you ever *observe* the invisible ones?

Readings. H&L ch. 1 — *the textbook at its most readable; start here.* Lukes, *Power: A Radical View* (selected pages) — *short, and the argument is the whole point. Read the third face twice.*

Teaching week 3 · Tue 29 September & Thu 1 October

Big question: where do states come from, and why can some of them actually do things?

- **Lecture 3 — The state I: where do states come from?** Weber's monopoly of legitimate violence; war, taxes and bureaucracy; Hobbes against Locke.
- **Lecture 4 — The state II: why can some states actually do things?** State capacity — coercive, extractive, administrative — and why it is not one number.

Readings. H&L ch. 3. Weber, "Politics as a Vocation" (selected pages) — *a century old and still the best definition anybody has written; dense in places, so give it time.*

Part II — Ideas and identities

Teaching week 4 · Tue 6 & Thu 8 October

Big question: what are the big answers to who gets what, and who decides?

- **Lecture 5 — Ideologies I: liberalism, conservatism, socialism.** Three serious answers to the distribution question, run against one live case.
- **Lecture 6 — Ideologies II: nationalism, fascism, feminism, green — and populism** as a *thin* ideology that attaches to any of them.

Readings. H&L ch. 2 — *a long chapter; skim the ideologies you think you already know and slow down on the ones you don't.* [TBD: Mudde or Müller on populism — short.]

Teaching week 5 · Tue 13 & Thu 15 October

Big question: where do political identities come from, and when does difference become conflict?

- **Lecture 7 — Where do political identities come from?** Why do some identities become political while most never do?
- **Lecture 8 — When does difference become conflict?** The real puzzle: most diverse societies, most of the time, have no ethnic violence.

Readings. H&L chs. 6 and 8 (selected sections). Fearon, “What Is Identity?” — *long and a little philosophical; read the opening and the section on identity categories, and don’t get stuck in the middle.*

Part III — Regimes

Teaching week 6 · Tue 20 & Thu 22 October

Big question: what is democracy, how would you measure it, and why does it survive?

- **Lecture 9 — Democracy: what it is, and how you’d measure it.** Minimal against substantive definitions; V-Dem, Freedom House, Polity, and three indices that disagree.
- **Lecture 10 — Democracy: why it emerges, why it survives.**

Readings. H&L ch. 4. Schmitter & Karl, “What Democracy Is... and Is Not” — *short and sweet, and the clearest ten pages on democracy you will read all term.*

Teaching week 7 — reading/review week, w/c Monday 26 October. No lectures, no tutorials. (Monday 26 October is a public holiday.) Teaching resumes with **teaching week 8 on Tuesday 3 November.** The blog post deadline sits around here — [TBD].

Teaching week 8 · Tue 3 & Thu 5 November

Big question: how do dictatorships actually work — and why do they bother holding elections?

- **Lecture 11 — Dictatorships I: how autocracies work.** Repression against co-optation.
- **Lecture 12 — Dictatorships II: elections, information, succession.** Why hold an election you could cancel? Why does nobody tell the autocrat the truth?

Readings. H&L ch. 5.

Teaching week 9 · Tue 10 & Thu 12 November

Big question: how do democracies rot — and how do you count something everybody hides?

- **Lecture 13 — Democratic backsliding.** Not a coup: a slow, legal-looking hollowing-out — courts, media, electoral administration, universities, in that order.
- **Lecture 14 — Corruption and state capture.** Why “everyone does it” is self-sustaining, and how you measure a thing people lie about.

Readings. [TBD: backsliding reading.] [TBD: corruption / state-capture reading.]

Part IV — Institutions and political economy

Teaching week 10 · Tue 17 & Thu 19 November

Big question: who can stop whom — and when do rules on paper actually bind rulers?

- **Lecture 15 — Who can stop whom?** Executives, legislatures and veto players — one framework you can carry to any country.
- **Lecture 16 — Rules that bind rulers.** Constitutions and courts, and when paper constraints hold.

Readings. H&L chs. 13–15 (selected sections) — *institutional detail; read for the argument, not the country lists.*

Teaching week 11 · Tue 24 & Thu 26 November

Big question: who gets what in the economy — and why doesn't more inequality produce more redistribution?

- **Lecture 17 — Political economy I: states, markets, globalisation.**
- **Lecture 18 — Political economy II: inequality, redistribution, housing.** Irish housing as a political-economy problem, not a policy-detail problem.

Readings. H&L ch. 7. [TBD: non-Heywood reading — ch. 7 does not cover the median voter or welfare regimes.]

Part V — Closing

Teaching week 12 · Tue 1 & Thu 3 December

Big question: why do we fail at long-horizon problems — and how would we ever know we were right?

- **Lecture 19 — Climate as a collective action problem.** Why democracies under-supply long-horizon goods.
- **Lecture 20 — How do we know?** Political science as detective work: how political scientists get fooled, and how they try not to be.

Readings. [TBD: collective action / climate politics reading.] [TBD: accessible causal-inference reading.]

Semester 1 teaching ends **Friday 4 December 2026**. The College assessment session runs **11–22 December 2026**.